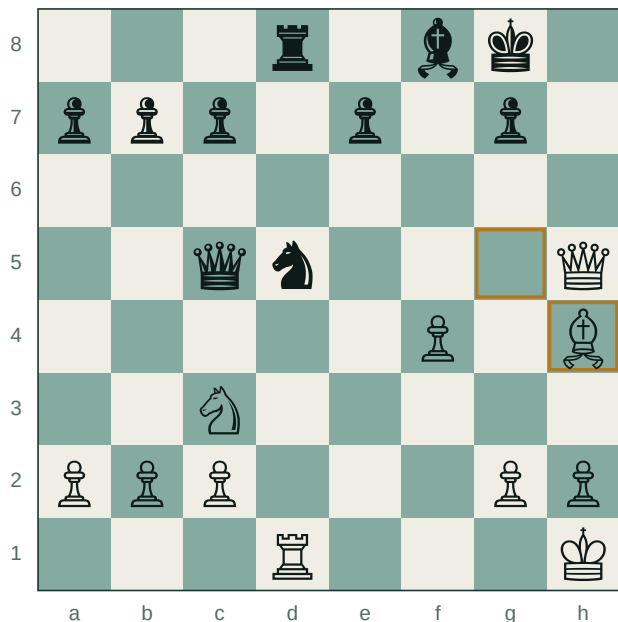


Capture the defender: Black, move 22

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 22.Bh4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22...Nxc3 23. Qxc5 Rxd1+ 24. Qg1 Rxc1+

22...Nxc3 The knight captures the knight on c3. The changed line means the rook on d8 attacks the rook on d1. Recorded reply: **23.Qxc5**.

23...Rxd1+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on d1. Recorded reply: **24.Qg1**.

24...Rxc1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the queen on g1.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +8:** the balance goes from -1 to +7. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: queen on h5. Check for tactical protection.